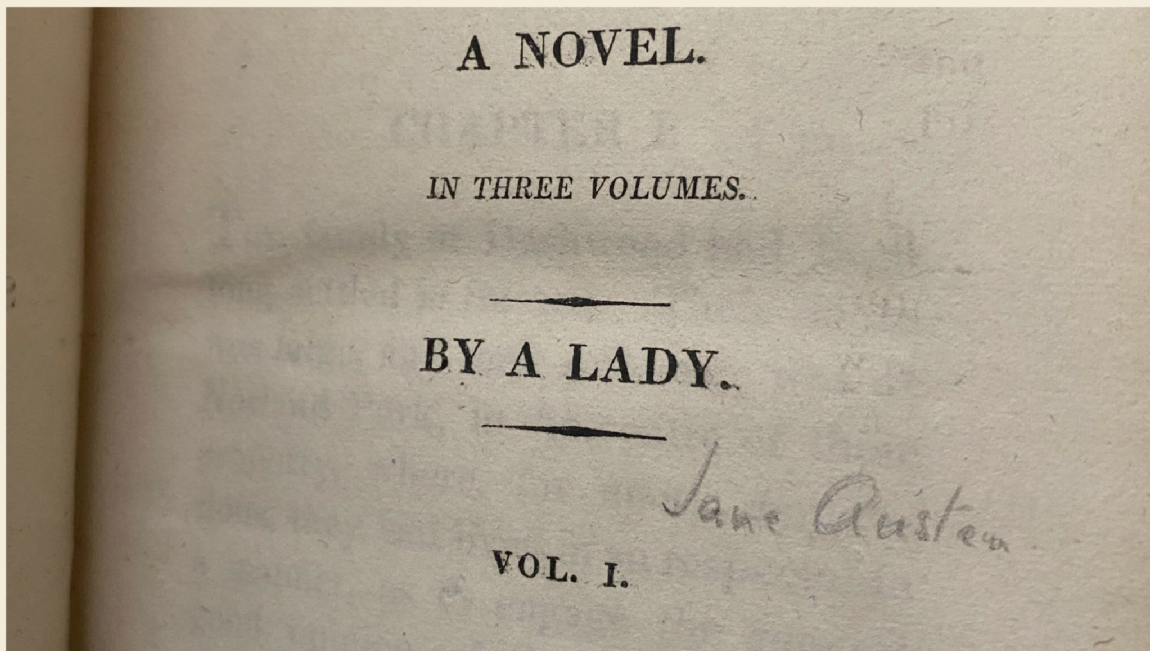

Library's first edition reveals Austen's early fans

26 September 2026

Bea Swallow, West of England



Longleat House: The book is evidence Austen's novels were being read and collected by the country-house elite during her own lifetime, say historians

A first edition of Jane Austen's debut novel has shed light on the author's connection with one of Britain's historic country houses.

The 1811 first edition of *Sense and Sensibility* is on the shelves at Longleat House in Wiltshire, with its title page still carrying the anonymous attribution "By A Lady".

It is thought to have been acquired by the 2nd Marquess of Bath around the time of its publication which historians say is evidence Austen was being read by the elite social class during her lifetime.

Dr James Ford, curator of Longleat House, said the estate had "a wonderful group of early Jane Austen editions", including *Emma* and *Pride and Prejudice*.

Sense and Sensibility follows the Dashwood sisters after their father's death leaves the family facing financial uncertainty. It follows the very different ways two young women navigate love, loss and society.

Bound in green and brown leather with a gold title, the relatively unassuming volume is among thousands of books in the seven historic libraries at Longleat House.

It is presumed Jane Austen signed her first novel "By a Lady" to maintain her anonymity.

Writing novels for money or public fame was generally considered unfeminine and improper for women of the gentry class during the 18th and 19th centuries.

Her identity as the author only became widely known after Austen's death in 1817, when her brother Henry identified his sister in a biographical notice.

The libraries at Longleat House contain a total collection of around 44,000 historic books, including first editions of Emma and a second edition of Pride and Prejudice.



Getty/Andrew_Harker: Longleat House has seven libraries containing a total collection of about 44,000 historic books

The edition is evidence that during her lifetime, Austen's books were being read and collected by the elite social class - the very social circle she depicted in her novels.

"An invoice we discovered last year records the 2nd Marquess purchasing Mansfield Park shortly after it was published in May 1814," Ford said.

"He was also one of the first owners of Longleat to open his park gates and hall door to early tourists, rather like the country house visit Austen evokes when Elizabeth Bennet arrives at Pemberley in Pride and Prejudice."

The historic libraries and rare book collections at Longleat can be visited as part of its Libraries VIP Tour.

A new adaptation of Sense and Sensibility arrives in UK cinemas on 25 September.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
shed light on	短语	揭示、使……更为了解	has shed light on the author’s connection with... 揭开作者与庄园的渊源；新闻高频
country house	n.	（英国）乡间大宅、贵族庄园	文化负载词；文中另见 country-house elite 庄园精英
title page	n.	扉页	印有书名的第一页；版权页称 copyright page
attribution	n.	署名、归属说明	the anonymous attribution “By A Lady” 匿名署名；动词 attribute 把……归于
acquire	v.	购得、获得（藏品）	收藏与博物馆语境高频；名词 acquisition 收购（的藏品）
it is thought / it is presumed	句型	据信、据推定	新闻避免把话说死的被动句式；后接不定式，如 it is thought to have been acquired
publication	n.	出版、问世	around the time of its publication 约在出版前后；另义“出版物”
curator	n.	策展人、馆藏负责人	curator of Longleat House 朗利特庄园的负责人
estate	n.	庄园、地产	此处指庄园产业，不是“遗产”；the estate had... 庄园藏有……
navigate	v.	应对、驾驭（处境）	navigate love, loss and society 在爱情、失亲

词	词性	中文	备注
			与社会中摸索；另义“导航”
unassuming	adj.	不起眼的、朴实的	the relatively unassuming volume 这本其貌不扬的书
volume	n.	(书的) 一卷、一册	此处指这本书；另义“音量；体积”
gentry	n.	(英国的) 乡绅阶层	women of the gentry class 乡绅阶层的女性；地位次于贵族、高于平民
notice	n.	小传、短评	a biographical notice 一篇生平小传；此处不是“通知、注意”
the very + 名词	短语	正是……、恰恰是……	the very social circle she depicted 正是她笔下的那个社交圈；强调用法
depict	v.	描绘、刻画	文学与艺术作品中的描写；近义词 portray
invoice	n.	发票、账单	An invoice records the purchase 一张发票记下这笔购买
rather like	短语	颇像、有点像	为比较降调的软表达，比 like 含蓄
evoke	v.	使人想起、唤起	evokes the country house visit 让人想起小说里的庄园之行
adaptation	n.	改编作品	a new adaptation of the novel 新版影视改编；动词 adapt